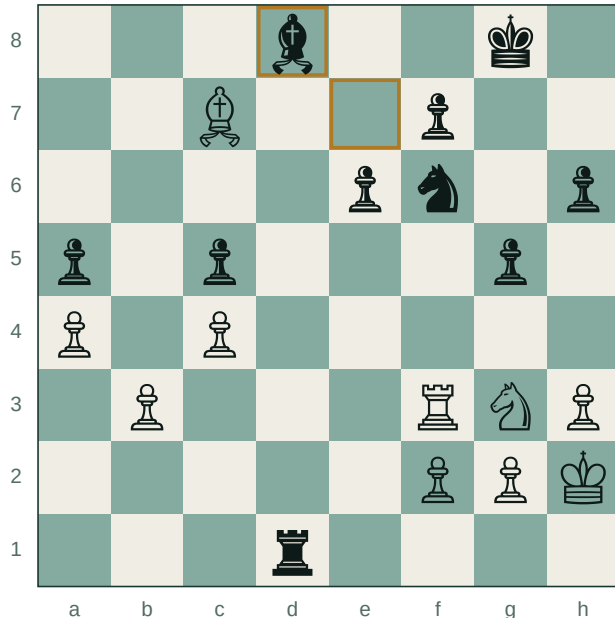


Capture the defender: White, move 35

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 34...Bd8. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

35. Bxd8 Rxd8 36. Rxf6

35.Bxd8 The bishop captures the bishop on d8. Recorded reply: **35...Rxd8**.

36.Rxf6 The rook captures the knight on f6.

At the end, nominal material is White 14 / Black 11 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: rook on d1. Check for tactical protection.